



# Alien Guitar Secrets

## LESSON 8.2: BUILDING CHORD PROGRESSIONS ON GUITAR

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### Introduction: The Foundation of Great Music

Chord progressions are the building blocks of songs, providing structure and a sense of movement. Whether you're writing original music, improvising, or learning your favorite songs, understanding how to build chord progressions on the guitar is an essential skill. The beauty of the guitar lies in its versatility—allowing you to create progressions that range from simple and familiar to complex and adventurous.

In this lesson, we'll cover the fundamentals of building chord progressions on guitar, explore different types of chords, and demonstrate how to use progressions to create mood and atmosphere. By the end of this lesson, you'll be able to create your own chord progressions and play them confidently across the fretboard.

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### Step 1: Understanding the Basics of Chord Progressions

#### What is a Chord Progression?

A chord progression is a sequence of chords played in a specific order, creating a harmonic structure for a song. Each chord in the progression has a specific function, which contributes to the overall mood and direction of the music.

#### Common Chord Progressions and Their Functions:

1. **I-IV-V-I:** One of the most common progressions in rock, pop, and blues. This progression uses the tonic (I), subdominant (IV), and dominant (V) chords to create a sense of stability and resolution.
  2. **I-vi-IV-V:** Known as the "50s progression," it adds an emotional quality with the use of the minor vi chord.
  3. **ii-V-I:** A staple in jazz and a great way to resolve to the tonic.
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### Step 2: Choosing Chords for Your Progression

#### 1. Start with a Key

Select a key for your progression. The key determines the set of chords you'll use and sets the tonal center of the song.

- **Example:** Key of C major (C, Dm, Em, F, G, Am, Bdim).

#### 2. Choose Chords Based on Their Function

Each chord has a specific role in a progression:



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- **Tonic (I):** Home base, establishes the key and provides resolution.
- **Subdominant (IV, ii):** Adds movement and sets up tension.
- **Dominant (V, vii):** Creates tension that wants to resolve back to the tonic.

## Example Progression in C Major:

- I - IV - V - I: C - F - G - C

## 3. Use the Nashville Number System

The Nashville Number System uses numbers (1-7) to represent chords in a key, making it easy to transpose and understand their functions.

### Example:

- I (C) - IV (F) - V (G) - vi (Am) in the key of C major.

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## Step 3: Adding Variety to Your Progressions

### 1. Use Minor Chords for Emotional Depth

Incorporating minor chords can add emotional depth and variety to your progressions. Minor chords have a sadder or more melancholic sound compared to major chords.

### Example:

- I - vi - IV - V: C - Am - F - G

### 2. Try Chord Extensions (7ths, 9ths, etc.)

Chord extensions, such as adding a 7th, 9th, or 13th, can enrich the sound of your progressions and add sophistication.

### Example:

- Cmaj7 - Dm7 - G7 - Cmaj7 (I-ii7-V7-I progression).

### 3. Use Suspended Chords for Tension

Suspended chords replace the 3rd of the chord with a 2nd (sus2) or 4th (sus4). This creates a sound that wants to resolve, adding tension and interest.

### Example:

- Csus4 - F - G - Csus2
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## Step 4: Experimenting with Chord Inversions and Voicings

Inversions change the order of notes in a chord, making it easier to move between chords and creating smooth transitions.

- **Example 1:** Play C major in root position (C - E - G) and then in 1st inversion (E - G - C).
- **Example 2:** Use a G/B chord (G major with B in the bass) to create a smooth transition from C to G.

Different voicings can also create unique textures. Experiment with open chords, barre chords, and triads on different string sets to find what works best for your progression.

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## Step 5: Creating Movement in Your Progression

### 1. Use Passing Chords

Passing chords are chords that are not in the key but are used to create smooth transitions between diatonic chords.

**Example:**

- C - Dm - E7 - F (E7 serves as a passing chord between Dm and F).

### 2. Add Secondary Dominants

Secondary dominants are dominant chords that resolve to a chord other than the tonic. They create tension and surprise.

**Example:**

- In C major: C - E7 - Am (E7 is the secondary dominant of Am, the vi chord).

### 3. Modulate to a New Key

Modulating, or changing keys, can add excitement and create a new emotional context for your progression.

**Example:**

- Start in C major: C - F - G - C.
  - Modulate to G major: G - C - D - G.
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## Step 6: Experimenting with Genre-Specific Progressions

### 1. Rock Progressions

Use power chords and the I-IV-V progression to build solid rock progressions. For added tension, try adding a minor vi chord or a sus chord.

#### Example:

- E5 - A5 - Dsus4 - E5

### 2. Blues Progressions

The 12-bar blues progression is a staple for blues players. Use dominant 7th chords for a bluesy feel.

#### Example:

- E7 - A7 - E7 - B7 - A7 - E7

### 3. Metal Progressions

Focus on minor chords, chromatic movement, and diminished chords for a dark, heavy sound.

#### Example:

- Em - F#dim - G - A5

### 4. Progressive Rock Progressions

Use extended chords, modulations, and irregular time signatures. Experiment with borrowed chords and modal interchange.

#### Example:

- Em7 - Cmaj7 - Gmaj7 - Abmaj7 (borrowing from parallel keys).

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## Exercises for Building Chord Progressions on Guitar

### Exercise 1: Create a Basic Progression and Add Complexity

1. Start with a simple progression (e.g., C - F - G - C).
2. Add a minor chord for contrast (e.g., Am).
3. Add extensions (e.g., Cmaj7, Fmaj7, G7).



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## **Exercise 2: Create Progressions in Different Keys**

1. Choose a key (e.g., D major).
2. Create a progression using I, IV, and V chords (e.g., D - G - A).
3. Modulate to a new key (e.g., switch to A major).

## **Exercise 3: Experiment with Suspended Chords and Inversions**

1. Replace a chord in your progression with a sus2 or sus4 chord.
2. Play a progression using inversions (e.g., C - G/B - Am - G).

## **Exercise 4: Write a Genre-Specific Progression**

1. Choose a genre (e.g., blues, rock, metal, or prog).
2. Write a progression that fits the genre using appropriate chords and techniques.
3. Practice playing it with different rhythms, tempos, and dynamics.



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## 10 POPULAR CHORD PROGRESSIONS OF ALL TIME

### 1. I–V–vi–IV (Major Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 1–5–6–4
  - **Mode:** Major (e.g., C major: C–G–Am–F)
  - **Characteristics:** Uplifting, versatile, and widely used in pop and rock music.
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### 2. vi–IV–I–V (Major Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 6–4–1–5
  - **Mode:** Major (e.g., A minor: Am–F–C–G)
  - **Characteristics:** Emotional and often used in ballads and modern pop songs.
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### 3. ii–V–I (Jazz Standard, Major Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 2–5–1
  - **Mode:** Major (e.g., C major: Dm–G–C)
  - **Characteristics:** Smooth and harmonically rich, common in jazz and swing.
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### 4. I–IV–vi–V (Major Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 1–4–6–5
  - **Mode:** Major (e.g., G major: G–C–Em–D)
  - **Characteristics:** Energetic and straightforward, often found in folk and rock.
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### 5. i–VII–VI–VII (Aeolian Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 1–7–6–7
  - **Mode:** Aeolian (e.g., A minor: Am–G–F–G)
  - **Characteristics:** Dark and moody, frequently used in alternative and indie music.
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## 6. I–V–vi–iii–IV–I–IV–V (Major Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 1–5–6–3–4–1–4–5
  - **Mode:** Major (e.g., C major: C–G–Am–Em–F–C–F–G)
  - **Characteristics:** Expansive and complex, often found in classical and sophisticated pop arrangements.
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## 7. I–IV–V–I (Major Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 1–4–5–1
  - **Mode:** Major (e.g., C major: C–F–G–C)
  - **Characteristics:** Classic and resolved, foundational in Western music.
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## 8. i–iv–VII–III–VI–ii°–V–i (Harmonic Minor Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 1–4–7–3–6–2°–5–1
  - **Mode:** Harmonic Minor (e.g., A minor: Am–Dm–G–C–F–Bdim–E–Am)
  - **Characteristics:** Dramatic and haunting, a staple in classical and cinematic music.
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## 9. IV–I–V–vi (Lydian Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 4–1–5–6
  - **Mode:** Lydian (e.g., G major: C–G–D–Em)
  - **Characteristics:** Dreamy and uplifting, common in progressive and experimental music.
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## 10. i–bVII–bVI–bVII (Dorian Mode)

- **Numerical Progression:** 1–b7–b6–b7
- **Mode:** Dorian (e.g., D minor: Dm–C–Bb–C)
- **Characteristics:** Optimistic with a minor edge, often used in funk and modal jazz.